

THE CALM MOM

Holiday Planner

OCTOBER - DECEMBER

A realistic planning system for busy working moms

GIFTS | WORK + SCHOOL | HOSTING | FAMILY PLANS



A Calmer Holiday Season

WELCOME · HOW TO USE THIS PLANNER



This planner is here to get the mental load out of your head and put the important pieces somewhere you can actually see them.

Christmas is not overwhelming because you forgot to make a gift list.

It is the gifts, work parties, school theme days, teacher presents, family celebrations, shipping deadlines, food, travel, and seventeen tiny things everyone assumes Mom already remembered.

HOW TO USE IT

- ☐ Start with the brain dump. Do not organize it yet - just get it out.
- ☐ Hand off anything that does not actually require you. Write the owner down so it leaves your brain too.
- ☐ Use the October, November, and December checklists as pacing guides, not commandments.
- ☐ Use the blank space. A useful planner gives you room to write, not tiny boxes to squeeze into.
- ☐ Print extra copies of gift, order, celebration, or event pages whenever your family needs them.

YOUR 10-MINUTE SETUP

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Pull up your work calendar | ☐ Check sports / activities |
| ☐ Pull up your partner's work calendar | ☐ Text family about known celebration dates |
| ☐ Open school + daycare calendars | ☐ Start the gift list with names only |

One thing I want this holiday season to feel like:

For personal use only. Print as many copies as you need for your own household.

START HERE

The Holiday Brain Dump

WORKSHEET



Get every loose thought out of your head before you try to organize any of it.

GIFTS + PEOPLE 	CALENDAR + COMMITMENTS
SCHOOL / DAYCARE / KIDS 	FOOD + HOSTING
HOME + TRAVEL 	WORK + EVERYTHING ELSE

Do not turn this into a to-do list yet. Some of this belongs on the skip list next.

START HERE

What We're Not Doing This Year



WORKSHEET

A calmer holiday starts by deciding what does not deserve your time.

THINGS WE ACTUALLY CARE ABOUT

THINGS WE'RE SIMPLIFYING

THINGS WE'RE SKIPPING COMPLETELY

You do not have to preserve every tradition simply because it existed last year.

October

CHECKLIST



Decide before the rush. Check it off, hand it off, or decide it does not belong on your list.

THIS MONTH'S PRIORITIES

☐
☐
☐
☐

TO DO

CALENDAR + LOGISTICS

☐ Add every known holiday commitment to the family calendar. Owner _____

☐ Check your work calendar for holiday events. Owner _____

☐ Check your partner's work calendar for holiday events. Owner _____

☐ Check school, daycare, sports, and activity calendars. Owner _____

☐ Confirm known family celebration dates and travel plans. Owner _____

GIFTS + SHOPPING

☐ Set a realistic holiday budget. Owner _____

☐ Start the master gift list and ask family for ideas. Owner _____

☐ Check kids' current clothing and shoe sizes. Owner _____

☐ Identify personalized or long-shipping gifts. Owner _____

☐ Inventory wrapping paper, gift bags, tags, tape, and cards. Owner _____

HOME + HOLIDAY PREP

☐ Decide who is hosting what. Owner _____

☐ Book photos, childcare, travel, or reservations if needed. Owner _____

☐ Do a quick toy / playroom declutter before new gifts arrive. Owner _____

☐ Note any traditions you are simplifying or skipping. Owner _____

☐ Start a list of teacher / caregiver gifts. Owner _____

November

CHECKLIST



Buy, prep, and protect your time. Check it off, hand it off, or decide it does not belong on your list.

THIS MONTH'S PRIORITIES

☐
☐
☐
☐

TO DO

GIFTS + ORDERS

☐ Buy priority gifts and personalized items. Owner _____

☐ Track Black Friday / Cyber Monday purchases against the actual list. Owner _____

☐ Wrap gifts as they arrive when possible. Owner _____

☐ Start stocking stuffers. Owner _____

☐ Create one return / exchange spot for incoming purchases. Owner _____

CALENDAR + PEOPLE

☐ Confirm family celebration dates and what you are bringing. Owner _____

☐ RSVP to work parties, friend gatherings, and kids events. Owner _____

☐ Put school / daycare theme days somewhere impossible to miss. Owner _____

☐ Confirm childcare for adult holiday events. Owner _____

☐ Finish teacher / caregiver gift plan. Owner _____

HOME + HOSTING

☐ Decide holiday menus and who is contributing what. Owner _____

☐ Inventory serving dishes, storage containers, and hosting basics. Owner _____

☐ Buy nonperishable hosting supplies. Owner _____

☐ Order holiday cards if your family sends them. Owner _____

☐ Block at least one quiet weekend or evening on purpose. Owner _____

December

CHECKLIST



Finish, simplify, enjoy. Check it off, hand it off, or decide it does not belong on your list.

THIS MONTH'S PRIORITIES

☐
☐
☐
☐

TO DO

FINISH THE OPEN LOOPS

☐ Finish remaining gifts and online orders. Owner _____

☐ Wrap the final gifts and label everything immediately. Owner _____

☐ Fill remaining stocking gaps. Owner _____

☐ Finish teacher / caregiver gifts. Owner _____

☐ Make final returns or exchanges that cannot wait. Owner _____

CALENDAR + KIDS

☐ Confirm every work, school, daycare, friend, and family event. Owner _____

☐ Put theme days and kids events somewhere impossible to miss. Owner _____

☐ Set aside holiday outfits and kids event clothing. Owner _____

☐ Pack travel / overnight items early. Owner _____

☐ Protect at least one evening with nothing scheduled. Owner _____

FOOD + CELEBRATIONS

☐ Group gifts by celebration so nothing goes to the wrong house. Owner _____

☐ Finalize menus and grocery lists. Owner _____

☐ Start make-ahead food that can be frozen or prepped. Owner _____

☐ Check batteries for toys and gifts that need them. Owner _____

☐ Charge cameras, power banks, and devices before the final week. Owner _____

October – December

AT A GLANCE



Big milestones only: deadlines, travel, celebrations, closures, work parties, performances, and anything that truly has to happen on a date.

OCTOBER	NOVEMBER	DECEMBER

Master Gift List



PAGE 1 OF 2

One list for everyone. Use both pages if you need them.

	RECIPIENT	GIFT IDEA	BUDGET	BOUGHT	WRAPPED	GIVEN
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Master Gift List



PAGE 2 OF 2

One list for everyone. Use both pages if you need them.

	RECIPIENT	GIFT IDEA	BUDGET	BOUGHT	WRAPPED	GIVEN
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Kids' Gift Planner

ONE PAGE PER CHILD



Print another copy of this page for each child you need to plan for.

CHILD _____

BUDGET _____

WANT 	NEED
WEAR 	READ
EXPERIENCE 	BIG GIFT

Already bought and hiding somewhere in this house:



Enough room for several people - because one tiny stocking somehow becomes twelve tiny purchases.

HALF CUP CALM · HALFCUPCALM.COM · PERSONAL USE ONLY

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

HALF CUP CALM · HALFCUPCALM.COM · PERSONAL USE ONLY

Holiday Budget

PLANNED VS ACTUAL



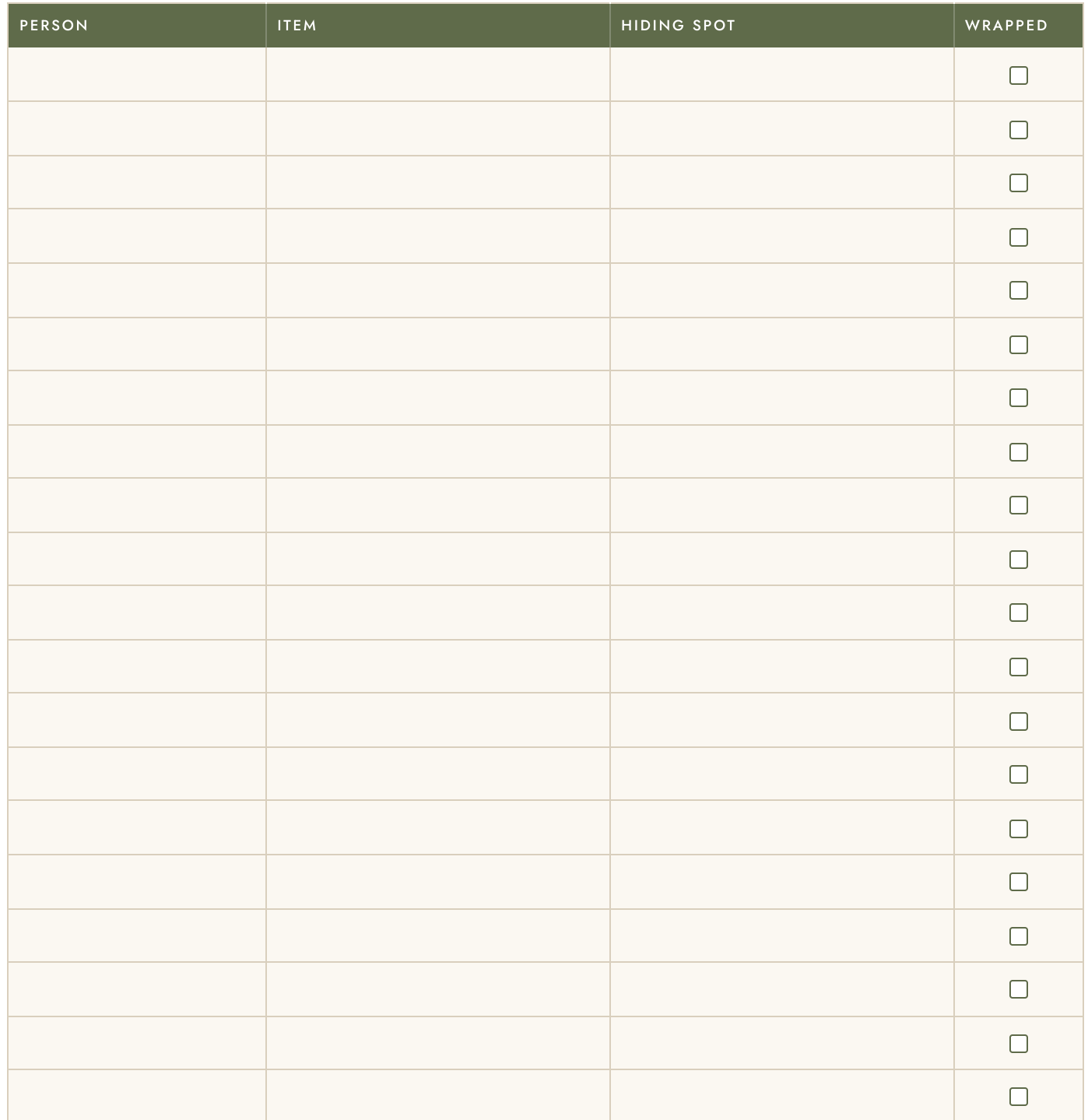
A simple reality check with enough room to track what the season is actually costing.

CATEGORY	PLANNED	ACTUAL	NOTES
Gifts			
Stockings			
Teacher / caregiver gifts			
Food + hosting			
Travel			
Events / tickets			
Decor			
Holiday clothing			
Cards / postage			
Childcare			
Convenience / delivery			
Giving / donations			
Other			
Other			

TOTAL HOLIDAY BUDGET _____ ACTUAL TOTAL _____

Budget note / boundary I want to remember:

Buying it early only helps if you can find it again.



Holiday Home Reset

CHECKLIST

Focus on what helps the house function. Baseboards are not invited.



DECLUTTER WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

- ☐ Entryway
- ☐ Living room surfaces
- ☐ Kitchen counters
- ☐ Fridge + freezer
- ☐ Guest bathroom
- ☐ Kids toy overflow
- ☐ Coat / shoe area
- ☐ Car

RESTOCK THE BORING THINGS

- ☐ Toilet paper
- ☐ Paper towels
- ☐ Hand soap
- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Dishwasher detergent
- ☐ Coffee / tea
- ☐ Easy breakfasts
- ☐ Kid snacks

QUICK HOME WINS

One room or zone I want reset before guests arrive:

One thing I can ignore until January:

You are preparing your home to function, not staging it for a magazine.

Holiday Hosting Plan



MENU + PREP

One page for the decisions that otherwise live in texts, notes, and your head.

DATE _____ TIME _____ GUEST COUNT _____ KIDS / BABIES _____

MENU PLAN		
COURSE	DISH	WHO'S BRINGING
APPETIZER		
MAIN COURSE		
SIDE DISHES		
DESSERT		
DRINKS		

PREP PLAN		
TASK	DATE	DONE
Seating		☐
Coats / entryway		☐
Kids setup		☐
Bathroom restock		☐
Serving pieces		☐
Leftover containers		☐
Drinks / ice		☐
Trash / recycling		☐
Music		☐
Pet plan		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

Holiday Menu

PLANNER



Plan the meal in categories so the menu does not become twelve side dishes and no breakfast.

BREAKFAST / BRUNCH 	APPETIZERS
MAIN 	SIDES
DESSERT 	KIDS
DRINKS 	NOTES / TIMING

Grocery List

SHOPPING

A full-page list with enough room for an actual holiday grocery run.



PRODUCE	BAKERY
DAIRY	MEAT / SEAFOOD
PANTRY	FROZEN
DRINKS	SNACKS / KID FOOD

Hosting + Household

SHOPPING LIST



Everything that is not technically groceries but somehow becomes urgent the day people arrive.

PAPER + DISPOSABLES	SERVING + STORAGE
DRINKS + ICE	CLEANUP + HOUSEHOLD
GUEST COMFORT	OTHER

Make-Ahead Food

PLAN



Future-you deserves fewer things happening at the exact same time.

MAKE NOW / FREEZE	1-2 DAYS BEFORE
MORNING OF	LAST MINUTE

THAW / MOVE TO FRIDGE _____



Pull the season out of separate calendars and put every known commitment in one place.

[illegible]

Work Parties + Adult Events

TRACKER



Your holiday calendar has a professional life too - yours and your partner's.

EVENT	WHOSE	DATE / TIME	LOCATION	DRESS / GIFT / BRING	CHILDCARE

BEFORE THE WEEK OF THE EVENT

☐ RSVP

☐ Childcare

☐ Outfit

☐ Gift exchange

☐ Dish / drink to bring

☐ Transportation

☐ Workday schedule impact

☐ Next-morning reality check

School + Daycare

DECEMBER CHAOS TRACKER



Because apparently December was not busy enough.

DATE	THEME / EVENT	CHILD	WHAT THEY NEED	READY
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Quick check: school calendar · daycare calendar · backpacks / folders · parent app / email

Kids' Parties + Performances

TRACKER

Parties, concerts, recitals, sports celebrations, class events, and everything else suddenly happening this month.



EVENT	DATE / TIME	WHERE	WEAR	BRING	GIFT?	PARENT?

Teacher + Caregiver Gifts

TRACKER



Keep appreciation thoughtful without accidentally creating a second gift department.

PERSON	CHILD	ROLE	GIFT IDEA	BUDGET	BOUGHT	GIVEN
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					☐	☐
					☐	☐
					☐	☐

You do not have to buy something for every person your child has spoken to since September.

Friends + Family Gatherings

TRACKER



Friendsmas, grandparents, cousins, neighborhood parties, brunches, Christmas Eve, and everything around the main celebration.

EVENT	HOST	DATE	BRINGING	GIFTS NEEDED	KIDS NEED	NOTES

Holiday Celebration

PLAN · #1



Use this for Christmas at home, grandparents, extended family, Christmas Eve, or any celebration that needs its own plan.

CELEBRATION _____ DATE _____

WHERE _____ ARRIVE / LEAVE _____

GIFTS / EXCHANGES	
WHO	WHAT WE ARE BRINGING / EXCHANGING

FOOD + CONTRIBUTION		
WE ARE MAKING	WE ARE BRINGING	NEED TO BUY

KIDS + LOGISTICS	
☐ Outfits	☐ Activities / toys
☐ Pajamas	☐ Nap / bedtime plan
☐ Diapers / wipes	☐ Medications
☐ Snacks	☐ Chargers

Holiday Celebration

PLAN · #2



Use this for Christmas at home, grandparents, extended family, Christmas Eve, or any celebration that needs its own plan.

CELEBRATION _____ DATE _____

WHERE _____ ARRIVE / LEAVE _____

GIFTS / EXCHANGES	
WHO	WHAT WE ARE BRINGING / EXCHANGING

FOOD + CONTRIBUTION		
WE ARE MAKING	WE ARE BRINGING	NEED TO BUY

KIDS + LOGISTICS	
☐ Outfits	☐ Activities / toys
☐ Pajamas	☐ Nap / bedtime plan
☐ Diapers / wipes	☐ Medications
☐ Snacks	☐ Chargers

Holiday Celebration

PLAN · #3



Use this for Christmas at home, grandparents, extended family, Christmas Eve, or any celebration that needs its own plan.

CELEBRATION _____ DATE _____

WHERE _____ ARRIVE / LEAVE _____

GIFTS / EXCHANGES	
WHO	WHAT WE ARE BRINGING / EXCHANGING

FOOD + CONTRIBUTION		
WE ARE MAKING	WE ARE BRINGING	NEED TO BUY

KIDS + LOGISTICS	
☐ Outfits	☐ Activities / toys
☐ Pajamas	☐ Nap / bedtime plan
☐ Diapers / wipes	☐ Medications
☐ Snacks	☐ Chargers

Bring-It Tracker

WHO GETS WHAT



The answer to: Wait, were we bringing dessert to your mom's or appetizers to my sister's?

EVENT	FOOD / DRINK	GIFTS	KID STUFF	OTHER	PACKED
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					☐
					☐

Delegate It

HAND-OFF LIST



You are the holiday planner. You do not need to be the entire holiday workforce.

TASK	WHO OWNS IT	WHEN	DONE
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			☐
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Easy hand-offs: wrapping · grocery pickup · RSVPs · teacher gift pickup · returns · bringing a dish · packing the car · one room of cleaning



Two Weeks Before Christmas

CHECKLIST

Close the biggest loops now so the final week can be lighter.

- ☐ Confirm remaining gift purchases and shipping deadlines.
- ☐ Wrap what is already in the house.
- ☐ Finish teacher and caregiver gifts.
- ☐ Confirm every celebration and what you are bringing.
- ☐ Check school / daycare theme days and events one more time.
- ☐ Buy nonperishable groceries and hosting supplies.
- ☐ Check holiday outfits for adults and kids.
- ☐ Check travel needs and overnight bags.
- ☐ Gather gifts by celebration.
- ☐ Check batteries for gifts and toys.
- ☐ Schedule grocery pickup if using one.
- ☐ Finish any returns that cannot wait.
- ☐ Move make-ahead food into the plan.
- ☐ Protect one quiet evening.

THE THREE THINGS THAT MATTER MOST NOW

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

One Week Before Christmas

CHECKLIST

Finish only what truly needs finishing. Everything else is optional.



- ☐ Finish remaining wrapping.
- ☐ Complete final grocery shop or pickup order.
- ☐ Prep make-ahead food.
- ☐ Pack gifts for each celebration.
- ☐ Pack kid gear for travel or long family days.
- ☐ Charge cameras, phones, power banks, and tablets.
- ☐ Put medications and essentials somewhere visible.
- ☐ Clear phone storage for photos if needed.
- ☐ Put returns in one place, not back into closets.
- ☐ Confirm arrival times and driving plans.
- ☐ Check the weather for travel / outdoor plans.
- ☐ Protect at least one quiet evening.
- ☐ Put batteries + screwdriver somewhere easy to find.
- ☐ Decide what can officially wait until January.

Still on my mind:

Christmas Eve

PLANNER

Set up tomorrow, then stop.



OUR PLANS

☐
☐
☐
☐

TO DO

☐

Set out Santa gifts.

☐

Fill stockings.

☐

Move anything that needs to thaw.

☐

Prep breakfast / brunch basics.

☐

Put batteries and a screwdriver somewhere obvious.

☐

Set aside medications and kid essentials.

☐

Assemble anything that absolutely cannot wait until morning.

☐

Put trash bags and recycling access somewhere convenient.

☐

Check coffee supplies.

☐

Do a five-minute kitchen reset.

☐

Put travel food / gifts together for tomorrow.

☐

Set out kids' outfits if that helps.

☐

Charge phones and cameras.

☐

Go to bed. Seriously.

One thing I want to remember tomorrow:

Christmas Day

THE DAY OF

Today is not a productivity challenge.



You planned what mattered. You handled the invisible stuff. Today's only job is to be here.

DON'T FORGET IF YOU'RE LEAVING THE HOUSE

☐ Medications

☐ Food that needs to travel

☐ Gifts for the next stop

☐ Kids comfort items

☐ Chargers

☐ Photos you actually want

☐ Anything in the fridge

☐ Nothing else unless it truly matters

Next stop / timing / anything we need to remember:

Little things I want to remember from today:

The After-Christmas Reset

CHECKLIST

Close the loops while everything is still fresh, then be done.



- ☐ Gather returns and exchanges.
- ☐ Use or organize gift cards.
- ☐ Send thank-yous if your family does them.
- ☐ Find homes for new toys and gifts.
- ☐ Create a donation pile for replaced items.
- ☐ Discard broken packaging and mystery cords.
- ☐ Update kids' sizes if new clothes changed what they need.
- ☐ Note gifts that were a huge hit.
- ☐ Note traditions that were more work than joy.
- ☐ Store decorations by area or category.
- ☐ Save reusable gift bags / boxes if you want them.
- ☐ Put receipts / warranties somewhere findable.

What can wait until January?

AFTER THE HOLIDAY

Notes for Next Christmas

FOR NEXT-YEAR-YOU



Give next-year-you the information you always wish you had.

DO AGAIN

NEVER AGAIN

BUY OR BOOK EARLIER

PEOPLE LOVED

I LOVED
